

Yet while the focus of military spending and air-force planning was on nuclear offense and defense, from the start of the Cold War very different demands were made on military aircraft and their crews as a variety of local crises and hot wars flared without escalating to nuclear conflict. The first of these was the Berlin Airlift of 1948–49, which brought hardworking

American and British transport aircraft briefly into the limelight usually hogged by the fighters and bombers.

The Berlin Airlift

The greatest supply operation in aviation history, the origins of the Berlin Airlift lay in the intended temporary division of defeated Germany and its ruined capital, Berlin, between the victorious allies. This left the Western powers in control of three sectors of Berlin deep within the Soviet-controlled area that later became East Germany. In the summer of 1948 the Soviets decided to take over the whole of Berlin. They blocked the overland corridors that linked the city to western Germany. With this lifeline cut off, the population of West Berlin – some 2.5 million people – would starve or freeze to death unless they accepted

communist rule and the Western allies withdrew. It was calculated that the Berliners would need 4,500 tons of food and fuel a day to survive the winter. When the airlift began, the USAF had 102 C-47s stationed in Europe, each capable of carrying a load of 3 tons. To anyone with simple arithmetic skills, it seemed obvious that an airlift could only be a token gesture. The American Military Governor of Germany, General Lucius Clay, said that even trying it would make people think he was “the craziest man in the world.” Yet the airlift quickly gathered pace. Four-engined C-54 Skymasters, capable of carrying a 10-ton load, were flown in from as far off as Hawaii and Alaska and swelled the supply armada. So did RAF Sunderland flying boats, landing on Berlin’s Havel lakes, and Avro Yorks, transports developed from Lancaster bombers. New airstrips



REMEMBRANCE STAMP

A West German commemorative stamp celebrates the “air bridge” that kept West Berlin supplied with food and fuel through the winter of 1948–49. Only a few years earlier, Allied aircraft had been bombing the city.

“The sound of the engines
is music to our ears.”

AN ANONYMOUS BERLINER

WRITING AT THE TIME
OF THE BERLIN AIRLIFT

